Winter Car-Kit Checklist

A checklist for the bag or bin that lives in your trunk all winter — plus a quick winterizing to-do list.

What this is

Two pages: a build-the-kit shopping checklist, and a one-evening “get the car winter-ready” checklist. Build the kit once, then a quick glance each November is all it takes.

How to use it

1. Page 2: check off what you already own, circle what to buy. The starred items are the “don't skip these” ones if you're on a budget.
2. Put everything in one duffel or storage bin in the trunk.
3. Page 3: work through the winterize list before the first freeze.
4. Re-check the kit each fall — flashlight batteries go stale.

Reminder: tire chains, snow socks, or winter tires are **model-specific** — your manual's tire section lists what's approved and how to mount them. Trust the manual over big-box-store advice at the shelf.

Printing tips: print one copy now, and tape a second copy inside your winter storage bin lid. Milder climate? The starred basics still earn their trunk space.

Winter Car-Kit

Check ✔ when it's IN the kit. ★ = most important if you buy only a few things.

Safety & warmth

- [ ] ★ Blanket, or a hooded emergency blanket
- [ ] ★ Flashlight + fresh spare batteries
- [ ] ★ First-aid kit (small store-bought one)
- [ ] ★ Phone charger / 12V usb cable + power bank
- [ ] Warm hat, gloves, spare socks (old ones are fine)
- [ ] Hand warmers (2–3 pairs)
- [ ] Whistle (cheap, loud, tiny)
- [ ] Water bottle or pouches (refill each fall)
- [ ] Snacks that survive cold (granola bars, nuts)
- [ ] Any daily medications you couldn't skip for a night

Getting unstuck & seen

- [ ] ★ Ice scraper / snow brush
- [ ] ★ Jumper cables or jump pack (charged)
- [ ] ★ Folding shovel, or any old small spade
- [ ] ★ Traction help: sand, cat litter, or traction mats
- [ ] Reflective triangles or LED flares (3)
- [ ] Tow strap (works only from the manual's proper tie points)
- [ ] Bright spare scarf or vest to wear in the dark
- [ ] Small tool kit / multi-tool
- [ ] Duct tape, a few zip ties
- [ ] Windshield de-icer spray

Verify with your manual: your manual's "Emergency" or "Winter driving" chapter often has a factory list of what your battery, cloths, and exact jack setup can and can't handle — worth two minutes before you shop.

Get Winter-Ready — One Evening

Do everything on page 1, then knock this out one evening per year. Most items are free.

- [ ] Wiper blades: replace if they smear (they're cheap and they die every 1–2 winters)
- [ ] Washer fluid: fill with **winter / de-icer** formula (the blue summer bug wash freezes)
- [ ] Tires: check pressure cold — it drops about 1 PSI per 10°F of temperature drop
- [ ] Tires: check tread with the quarter test (head up; if Washington's head is covered, you're OK)
- [ ] Battery: 3+ years old? Have it tested free at most parts stores before a cold snap
- [ ] Oil / fluids: schedule a service if one is due in the next month
- [ ] Headlights / brake lights: have someone watch while you flip each one
- [ ] Scrape the inside windows once — they fog worse than you think
- [ ] Clear snow off the roof too, not just the windshield (it slides onto yours at speed)
- [ ] Leave the fuel level above 1/4 tank (keeps fuel lines and a warm cabin safer)
- [ ] Test defrosters front AND rear
- [ ] Put the kit from page 2 in the trunk (where it will actually live this year)
- [ ] Make sure the spare tire still holds air (and you remember where it hides)

Winter notes for this year

KIT COMPLETED ON	WINTERIZE DONE ON	TO BUY NEXT FALL

Verify with your manual: on jump-start, before chains, before towing — the manual's exact steps matter and save belts, hoods, and warranties.